

Strengthening Disability-Inclusive Sexual and Reproductive Health Services in Homa Bay County

Executive Summary

Persons with disabilities experience many of the same sexual and reproductive health needs as everyone else. However, they often face additional barriers such as physical inaccessibility, limited communication channels, stigma and discrimination. Women and girls with disabilities are also at increased risk of sexual and gender-based violence, yet they often face greater difficulty reporting abuse or accessing timely medical, psychosocial and legal support.

Homa Bay County has taken an important step towards protecting the rights of persons with disabilities (PWDs) through the **Homa Bay County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence (SGBV) Policy (2022)**, which recognizes persons with disabilities as one of the groups most vulnerable to sexual and gender-based violence. The policy further demonstrates the county's commitment to inclusion by involving organisations of persons with disabilities in policy development and providing the disability, representatives within county implementation structures.

While these commitments provide a strong foundation, persons with disabilities continue to face significant barriers in accessing sexual and reproductive health information and services. Physical inaccessibility of health facilities, communication barriers, limited disability-inclusive SRHR services and inadequate knowledge of healthcare providers to prevent or broach the distinct needs of many women, men, adolescents and young people with disabilities from receiving the healthcare they need.

This policy brief outlines practical actions that Homa Bay County can take to operationalize these commitments by strengthening disability-inclusive health infrastructure, improving provider capacity, increasing access to information in accessible formats and strengthening accountability for inclusive SRHR service delivery.



Why This Matters

Investing in disability inclusive SRHR services will help Homabay County to:

Improve access to quality reproductive healthcare for persons with disabilities.

Reduce barriers to maternal, newborn and adolescent health services.

Improve access to timely, life-saving information and services.

Strengthen prevention and response to sexual and gender-based violence.

Promote equity and ensure no one is left behind.

Homa Bay Has Already Laid the Foundation

The Homa Bay County Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Policy (2022) demonstrates the county's commitment to disability inclusion in three important ways:



Recognition of Vulnerability:

The policy recognizes persons with disabilities as one of the groups most vulnerable to sexual and gender-based violence and prioritizes targeted protection and support.



Inclusive Policy Development:

The policy was developed with the participation of the Homa Bay County Disability Forum and Organisations of Persons with Disabilities, embedding their voices into the policy from the outset.



Representation in Implementation:

The policy provides for representation of persons with disabilities through the Department of Social Services within the county's multi-sectoral implementation and monitoring structure.

County Implementation Scorecard

IMPLEMENTATION AREA	CURRENT STATUS	PRIORITY ACTION
Accessible SRHR and GBV infrastructure	Low	Upgrade health facilities, PSS centres and GBV recovery services to meet accessibility standards.
Disability-inclusive communication	Low	Produce accessible IEC materials and strengthen Kenyan Sign Language interpretation.
Frontline provider capacity	Moderate	Train health workers, police officers and social service providers on disability-inclusive SRHR and GBV response.
Participation of persons with disabilities	Established but needs strengthening	Increase meaningful participation of OPDs in county planning, budgeting and monitoring.
Disability-responsive budgeting	Low	Allocate dedicated resources for disability-inclusive SRHR and GBV interventions.
Monitoring and reporting	Low	Collect disability-disaggregated SRHR and GBV data and report progress regularly.



Priority Actions for Strengthening Disability-Inclusive SRHR Services in Homa Bay County

PRIORITY AREA	WHO SHOULD LEAD?	PRIORITY ACTIONS	HOW THIS ADVANCES SRHR FOR PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES
Improve Accessibility of SRHR Services	County Department of Health (DoH), Department of Public Works, County Facility Management Teams	Remodel health facilities with ramps, accessible toilets and tactile signage. Establish mobile outreach units and telehealth services.	Removes physical barriers that prevent persons with disabilities from accessing essential SRHR services, including maternal care, HIV delivery, FP services and post-GBV care, and other essential SRHR services.
Build Capacity of Frontline Service Providers	County Department of Health, Department of Social Services, Kenya School of Government, Professional Councils	Train healthcare workers, police officers, legal officers and social service providers on disability rights and disability-inclusive SRHR service delivery. Build skills in respectful care, communication, GBV disability confidentiality and response decision-making.	Improves the quality of care and reduces stigma, discrimination and communication barriers that discourage persons with disabilities from seeking SRHR services.
Strengthen Budget Accountability	County Treasury, County Health Department, Department of Social Services	Increase awareness on health financing, avail SRHR service expenditures and track accessible IEC materials, disability-inclusive outreach programmes and health worker training.	Ensures disability inclusion is adequately funded and monitored, leading to accountable implementation and improved, long-term access to quality SRHR services for persons with disabilities.
Improve Data and Accountability	County Health Information Units, DoH, Monitoring and Evaluation Unit	Monitor access to family planning, antenatal care, maternal health, HIV, cancer screening and GBV services among persons with disabilities. Use evidence to improve planning and resource allocation.	Helps identify service gaps, monitor progress toward SRHR service inclusion and ensures the county's interventions respond to the specific needs and experiences of persons with disabilities.

Together, we can ensure that no one is left behind in accessing sexual and reproductive health rights and services.